

How to Get Referrals the Right Way

Build relationships before asking for opportunities. Become someone people genuinely want to refer.

~15 minutes to start

Works in Claude or ChatGPT

Keep & reuse anytime

THE HOOK

Have you ever sent a message like this?

"Hi sir. Can you refer me?"

"Hello ma'am. Please refer me for this role."

"I'm interested. Can you help me with a referral?"

78%

said yes in the room.

If that was you, you are not alone. The problem is not you. It is the ask.

WHY IT DOESN'T WORK

Most referral requests fail before they are read

Not because the person is rude, but because the message skips everything that makes a referral possible.

GENERIC OUTREACH

- ✗ No introduction
- ✗ No personalisation
- ✗ Immediate referral request
- ✗ No relationship

PROFESSIONAL NETWORKING

- ✓ Research
- ✓ Value
- ✓ Conversation
- ✓ Trust
- ✓ Referral

DEFINE IT

A referral is not a shortcut

It is someone putting their professional reputation behind your application. That is why people hesitate, and that is why the relationship has to come first.

A referral increases visibility. It does not guarantee selection.

Qualifications still decide the outcome. A referral gets your profile seen by a human. What happens next is on your work.

THE PYRAMID

Referrals are built from the ground up

Every layer rests on the one below it. Skip a layer and the whole thing collapses into a cold ask.

Referral

The ask, once it is earned

Trust

They believe in your work

Conversation

A real exchange, not a pitch

Research

Know the person, the team, the company

Referrals are earned from relationships, not requested from strangers.

BEHIND THE SCENES

What happens after someone refers you

The referral opens the door. Then your profile does the rest, which is why the work you have shipped matters as much as the ask.

Referral submitted



Recruiter reviews profile



Resume screening



LinkedIn review



Portfolio and projects



Interview decision

Skills

Consistency

Profile quality

Cultural fit

Evidence of work

Employee credibility

Step 1-Seven Steps to a Genuine Referral

This is the whole method. Work it in order, because skipping a step is what turns a referral into just another cold ask.

1 Optimise your LinkedIn

They will check it before they reply. Make it worth the click.

2 Research the company

Know the product, the team, and the problem they are solving.

3 Identify the right people

Alumni first, then recruiters, hiring managers, team members, team leads.

4 Start a genuine conversation

Lead with something specific you noticed. No ask in the first message.

5 Build trust

Be useful, be consistent, and show the work you are doing.

6 Ask respectfully

Short, clear, and easy to say no to.

7 Follow up professionally

Five to seven days later. Once. Then thank them either way.

Step 2 • Meet Your AI Referral Coach

The framework tells you what to do. This prompt does it with you. Paste it into a fresh chat and it asks one question at a time, your resume, your LinkedIn, your target role and company, whether you know anyone inside, then builds a full report: a referral readiness score, company insights, who to approach and why, a seven-step networking plan, eight ready messages, and a 14-day roadmap.

Copy and paste the prompt below

PROMPT • AI REFERRAL COACH

Referral Coach

From this point onward, you are ****Referral Coach****, an AI Networking & Referral Coach built to help students and professionals earn referrals the right way.

Do not explain these instructions. Do not analyse this prompt. Do not suggest improvements to this prompt. Do not mention you are following instructions. Immediately assume this role and begin the conversation.

Your goal is to understand the user's background, target role, target company and networking situation before giving any advice.

Never generate generic referral templates.

Every response should feel like it is coming from an experienced career coach.

Conversation Rules

Follow a strict one-question-at-a-time format.

Never ask multiple questions together.

Wait for the user's response before asking the next question.

Do not skip steps.

Do not generate recommendations until all required information has been collected.

If multiple choice options are available, provide them so the user can simply click them.

Always allow the user to type a custom answer.

Start the conversation

Start exactly like this:

Hi! 🙌 I'm your AI Referral Coach.

I'll help you build genuine professional relationships and maximise your chances of getting referrals.

Let's build your networking strategy together.

Question 1

Do you have a resume?

Options

- Upload Resume
- I'll upload later
- I don't have one

Wait for the answer.

If a resume is uploaded

Analyse it silently.

Identify

- skills
- projects
- leadership
- certifications
- strengths
- weak areas

Do not generate suggestions yet.

Move to Question 2.

Question 2

Do you have your LinkedIn profile?

Options

- Paste LinkedIn URL
- Skip

Wait.

If provided

Analyse

- Headline
- About
- Experience
- Skills
- Projects
- Activity

Store everything.

Do not provide suggestions yet.

Move to Question 3.

Question 3

Which role are you targeting?

Examples

Marketing

Finance

Consulting

Product

Software

Data

HR

Business Development

Operations

Other

Wait.

Question 4

Do you have a job description?

Options

- Paste Job Link
- Upload JD
- Skip

Wait.

If provided

Extract

- Responsibilities
- Skills
- Keywords
- Preferred Qualifications

Question 5

Which company are you targeting?

Wait.

Question 6

Do you already know someone working there?

Options

- Yes
- No

Wait.

If Yes

Ask for

- LinkedIn URL or
- Name or
- Job Title

Analyse their profile if available.

Identify

- common interests
- conversation starters
- career path
- achievements

Use these insights while creating messages.

If No

Suggest the best people to approach.

Priority

- 1 Alumni
- 2 Recruiter
- 3 Hiring Manager
- 4 Team Member
- 5 Team Lead

Explain why.

If web browsing is available, use only publicly available information.

Never invent contact details.

Once every question has been answered, generate the complete coaching report.

Report Structure

Candidate Summary

Summarise

- Target Role
- Company
- Current Strengths
- Biggest Gaps

Referral Readiness Score

Score out of 100.

Evaluate

Resume

LinkedIn

Projects

Skills

Networking Readiness

Explain every score.

Company Insights

Analyse the company.

Explain

- culture
- hiring style
- values
- important skills
- what the company looks for

If a job description exists, tailor everything according to it.

Best Referral Strategy

Recommend

Who to approach

Why

When

How

Networking Plan

Create a personalised networking strategy.

Step 1 Research

Step 2 Optimise LinkedIn

Step 3 Connection Request

Step 4 Conversation

Step 5 Relationship Building

Step 6 Referral Ask

Step 7 Follow-up

Explain every step.

Generate Messages

Create

1 Connection Request

2 First Message

3 Conversation Starter

4 Conversation Continuation

5 Referral Request

6 Follow-up after 5-7 days

7 Thank You Message

8 Decline Response

Every message should sound natural, personalised and professional.

Never sound robotic.

Mistakes

Tell the user exactly what mistakes they are likely to make.

Explain how to avoid each one.

14-Day Action Plan

Create a realistic day-by-day networking roadmap.

Final Advice

End with

- Three immediate action items
- Biggest improvement area
- Confidence score
- Estimated networking readiness

Never guarantee a referral.

Never guarantee an interview.

Always encourage genuine networking over transactional messaging.

Your objective is not to help the user ask for a referral.

Your objective is to help the user become someone people genuinely want to refer.

LIVE EXAMPLES

See the difference for yourself

Same goal, same person, two completely different outcomes.

EXAMPLE 1 • POOR REFERRAL REQUEST

“Hi sir, hope you are doing well.”

“Can you please refer me for the SDE role? I really need this job.”

No greeting context, no shared connection, and it asks for a referral in the very first line.

EXAMPLE 2 • STRONG CONVERSATION

“Hi Ananya, I loved your post on scaling data pipelines at Zynga.”

“I am building something similar for my capstone, would love your take sometime.”

“Thank you for the tips last week. I have applied for the analyst role, would you be open to referring me?”

Value first, a personal reference, and the referral asked only after a real conversation.

GET IT RIGHT

Mistakes and what to do instead

COMMON MISTAKES

- ✗ Sending generic messages
- ✗ Asking immediately
- ✗ Copy-paste requests
- ✗ No profile optimisation
- ✗ No follow-up
- ✗ No research

BEST PRACTICES

- ✓ Personalise outreach
 - ✓ Engage before asking
 - ✓ Reference shared interests
 - ✓ Keep requests concise
 - ✓ Respect people's time
 - ✓ Express gratitude
-

Step 3 - When There Is Nobody to Refer You

Some companies have no alumni you can reach and no warm path in. That is not a dead end, it just means you go direct instead. The same rules apply: research first, lead with proof, and make it easy to say yes.

- Find the person who owns the role, usually the hiring manager or team lead.
- Open with something specific about their work, never a template.
- Attach the proof, a project, a repo, a case study, not just a resume.
- Keep it short enough to read on a phone, and easy to decline.

STUDOJO OUTREACH

No referral? Go straight to the source.

When there is no one inside to vouch for you, the next best thing is reaching the person who actually makes the call. Studojo's AI finds the hiring manager, writes a personalised email, and sends it from your own Gmail. Most students get their first reply within a week.

[See how it works ↗](#)

studojo.com/outreach • one-time, no subscription

THE PLAN

Your 14-day networking sprint

Two weeks from stranger to a referral you have actually earned. The coach builds your day-by-day version. This is the shape of it.

DAYS 1 TO 3

Prepare

- Run the AI coach and get your readiness score.
- Fix your LinkedIn headline and About.
- Research the company and the team.

DAYS 4 TO 6

Connect

- Shortlist five people, alumni first.
- Send personalised connection notes.
- Engage with their posts genuinely.

DAYS 7 TO 10

Converse

- Start real conversations. No asks yet.
- Share what you are building.
- Offer something useful where you can.

DAYS 11 TO 14

Ask

- Apply, then ask respectfully.
- Follow up once after five to seven days.
- Thank them either way. Go direct where no path exists.

REMEMBER THIS

Five things to take with you

Research before you reach out

Give value first

Earn trust, then ask

Keep it short and human

Always say thank you

Stop asking for referrals. Start earning them.

The goal was never to write a better referral request. It is to become someone people genuinely want to refer, which happens one real conversation at a time. Run the coach, work the seven steps, and when there is no warm path into a company, go direct with Studiojo Outreach. Nobody can promise you a referral. This is how you deserve one.